

Habilidades Comunicativas en Lengua Extranjera
Profesional (Inglés)

Unit 3. Public Speaking and Meetings

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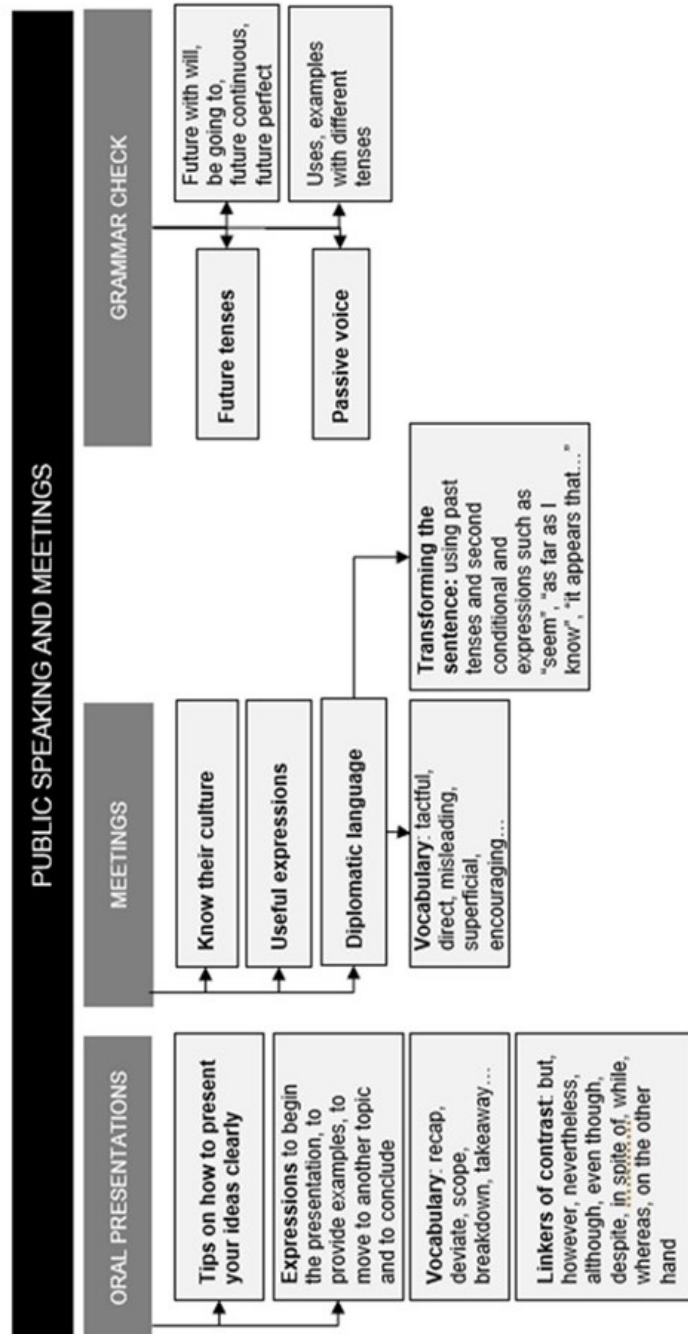
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3.1. Introduction and Objectives

Effective public speaking and meetings are crucial in professional and academic environments. The ability to deliver structured and engaging oral presentations is a key skill that enhances communication, persuasion and clarity. This unit will focus on developing the necessary techniques to structure and deliver oral presentations effectively, ensuring confidence and impact when speaking in front of an audience. Additionally, we will reinforce essential grammar structures, including future tenses, modal verbs, and passive voice, which are fundamental for clear and professional communication.

- ▶ **Objective 1:** Understand the fundamentals of public speaking and meetings by analysing key strategies for effective communication.
- ▶ **Objective 2:** Structure and deliver oral presentations with a logical organisation, engaging content and clear pronunciation.
- ▶ **Objective 3:** Develop confidence in public speaking by practising techniques to control nerves, engage the audience and use body language effectively.
- ▶ **Objective 4:** Apply appropriate grammar structures in spoken and written communication, focusing on future tenses and passive voice.

3.2. Oral presentations

How to present your ideas clearly

How to present your ideas clearly

In the In Depth section, you can find a very interesting video on how to present your ideas clearly following three simple steps.

- ▶ What are the **three main strategies** mentioned for improving clarity in presentations?
- ▶ Why is it important to use **simple language** during a presentation?
- ▶ Describe the significance of **practicing** a presentation with someone unfamiliar with the topic.
- ▶ Can you think of **more tips** to make sure a presentation is clear?

Useful vocabulary and expressions

To start, let's see some common expressions to use in oral presentations:

BEGINNING A PRESENTATION	EXPLAINING, GIVING EXAMPLES	MOVING TO ANOTHER TOPIC	FINISHING A PRESENTATION
I'm going to tell you about...	Let me show you an example of...	I'd like to turn to...	I'll sum up by saying...
Let me start with	As you can see...	Let's move on to...	In summary, ...

Table 1. Useful expressions in oral presentations. Source: author original.

Example 1

Expressions for oral presentations

Hello everyone! **Today I'm going to tell you about** our marketplace app's new voice search feature. **Let's start with** the most important thing: how it works. Instead of typing, you just say what you're looking for – as easy as that. **Let me show you an example of** the voice search. I say: 'Find running shoes in my size.' **As you can see** on the screen, it shows you hundreds of running shoes to choose from! **Now I'd like to turn to** some numbers. Typing and then filtering the search results can usually take you about a minute. In contrast, with the voice search, it's no more than five seconds. **Let's move on to** how this can affect our customers' behaviour. This quarter, we expect that the number of people who buy something from us will grow by five to ten per cent. That might mean a little salary increase, ha ha. **I'll sum up by saying** that this feature is about simplicity. It will make the searches faster, the customers happier, and the number of buyers greater. Do you have any questions?

When talking about oral presentations, there are some important words to bear in mind, for example:

- ▶ **Deviate:** to start talking about something irrelevant to the topic. *It's important not to deviate from the plan.*
- ▶ **Recap:** the act of repeating the main points. *Before we move on, let's do a quick recap of what we have discussed in today's meeting.*
- ▶ **Takeaway:** the main idea of the presentation. *The main takeaway of the presentation was that we need to improve communication.*

- ▶ **Scope:** the range of the topic covered in the presentation. *The scope of the project includes developing a new website.*
- ▶ **Breakdown:** a division of information into parts so that you can see all details. *The breakdown of the data revealed some unexpected trends that we need to address.*
- ▶ **Outline:** description of something without details. *The professor asked us to provide an outline of our research before submitting the final paper.*

There are more expressions you can use. Focus also on the prepositions used in each of them.

- ▶ **In a nutshell**, this idea is worth a shot. : en resumen, en pocas palabras
- ▶ **Let me start by saying** a few words about my background: permíteme empezar diciendo...
- ▶ **Let me expand on** this point: permíteme expandirme/ampliar este punto.
- ▶ Well, **this brings me to the end** of my presentation: esto me lleva al final de mi presentación.
- ▶ Let me just **run through** the main takeaway again: permíteme que vuelva a repasar...
- ▶ **Let's kick off by discussing** the influence of this trend: empecemos por...

Linkers of contrast

When giving oral presentations, you will need some linkers to compare and contrast your ideas. Here you will find the main ones and their uses:

BUT	HOWEVER
• Used to connect contrasting ideas. • Can't use "but" at the beginning of a sentence. • She always wants to be successful, but she is so lazy. • I'm not sure what you are planning to do, but I will always support you.	• More formal than "but". • You can use "however" at the beginning of a sentence, and always followed by a comma (,). • We have failed many times. However, we keep trying. • I want to go to your party. However, I must visit my parents.

Table 2. Linkers: but and however. Source: author original.

NEVERTHELESS
• More formal than "however" but means the same. • You can use it at the beginning or at the end of a sentence. • He said his English is terrible. Nevertheless, he got an 8 on his English test. • I knew a lot about the subject already, but his presentation was interesting nevertheless.

Table 3. Linkers: nevertheless. Source: author original.

ALTHOUGH / EVEN THOUGH

- Followed by Subject + Verb
- Even though: given condition is negative, but the result is positive.
- Although: given condition is positive, but the result is negative.
- You can use them at the beginning or in the middle of a sentence.
- **Even though** Ram hadn't studied, he passed the exam.
- **Although** Ram had studied very hard, he didn't pass the exam.

Table 4. Linkers: although and even though. Source: author original.

DESPITE / IN SPITE OF

- Similar meaning to although/ even though.
- Followed by VERB + ING (gerund).
- Followed by noun.
- Followed by pronoun.
- **Despite** the rain, we enjoyed the festival. (despite + noun)
- **Despite** having a headache, I had a great birthday. (despite + gerund)
- They never made much money **in spite of** their success. (in spite of + pronoun)
- If you want to use a clause (subject + verb), you need to add "the fact that"
- **Despite the fact that** Mike is successful at work, he is not happy.
- **In spite of the fact that** Mike studied hard, he didn't pass the exam.

Table 5. Linkers: despite and in spite of. Source: author original.

WHILE / WHEREAS
• Can be used at the beginning or in the middle • While I accept that he's not perfect, I like him. • She likes going to parties whereas I prefer staying at home.

Table 6. Linkers: while and whereas. Source: author original.

ON THE OTHER HAND
• To introduce the second of two contrasting ideas. • Can be used at the beginning or in the middle. • She lacked experience, but on the other hand she was hard-working. • I don't want to see him. On the other hand, I still have something to tell him.

Table 7. Linkers: on the other hand. Source: author original.

3.3. Meetings

Know your culture. Greetings.

When working with different cultures in business, it's important to recognise various behavioral differences. One notable example is how people greet each other. The common Spanish greeting of two kisses is not typically seen in American or British cultures, though kissing is a customary greeting in some other places, such as:

- ▶ **Netherlands:** three kisses, starting and finishing on the right cheek.
- ▶ **Italy:** while handshakes are common, kisses are exchanged between family and friends.
- ▶ **Belgium:** a single kiss on the cheek is usual, and three kisses are given to elders as a sign of respect.
- ▶ **Austria and Scandinavia:** they share similar greeting practices as Spain.
- ▶ **Germany:** handshakes are the more frequent form of greeting.

Know their culture

If you want to know more about Greetings, in the In Depth section, you can find a very interesting article on some international business etiquette practices in different countries.

Meeting terminology

There are some common expressions you can use in meetings. As always, pay special attention to the prepositions used in each of them.

- ▶ Starting the meeting:
 - **Let's get down to business**: pongámonos manos a la obra.
 - **We'd better start**: será mejor que empecemos.
 - **I'd like to begin with/by...** : me gustaría empezar por...
 - **I'd kick off by** saying... : me gustaría empezar diciendo...
- ▶ Following an agenda:
 - **As you can see from the agenda...** : como verán en la orden del día...
 - **First of all, we must consider/examine/bear in mind** : en primer lugar, tenemos que considerar/tener en mente...
 - **I suggest we take this item first**: sugiero que empecemos por este punto primero...
 - **Let's start by** looking at the issue of...: empecemos con el asunto de...
- ▶ Introducing points:
 - **Turning to... / Moving on to...** : pasando a...
 - **In addition... / Additionally, ...** : además...
 - **We should also think about...** : también deberíamos pensar en...

► Considering alternatives:

- **Although..., we must remember that...** : aunque..., tenemos que recordar que...
- **In spite of... I still think that...** : a pesar de..., aun así creo que...
- **On the one hand, ... but on the other hand...** : por un lado..., pero por otro lado...

► Introducing questions:

- **Have you considered...?** : ¿Has pensado en...?
- **Do you realise / know that...?** : ¿Te das cuenta de que...?
- **Wouldn't you agree that...?** : ¿No estarías de acuerdo en que...?

► Expressing certainty:

- **I'm 100 percent certain that...** : estoy cien por cien seguro de que...
- **There's no doubt...** : no hay duda de...
- **There is a possibility that...** : hay una posibilidad de que...

► Summarising:

- **So, to sum up...** : entonces, resumiendo...
- **In short, ...** : en resumidas cuentas...

► Concluding the meeting:

- Let me **wrap up by** saying... : déjame concluir diciendo...
- **In conclusion, I would like to reiterate...** : en conclusión, me gustaría reiterar...
- **I would like to conclude by...** : me gustaría concluir con...

Diplomatic language

Being diplomatic is being skillful and careful in the way that you express your thoughts and ideas in difficult situations.

Reflect on the following questions:

- ▶ In which situations do you think you might need to be diplomatic?
- ▶ Which situations have you been in when you have needed to be diplomatic?

When talking about diplomatic language, there are some important words to bear in mind:

- ▶ **Tactful**: saying and doing things that are aware of other people's feelings.
- ▶ **Direct**: saying exactly what you mean.
- ▶ **Dishonest**: acting or speaking in a way that is lying to people.
- ▶ **Superficial**: showing a lack of deep thought or understanding.
- ▶ **Misleading**: making people believe something is true when it isn't.
- ▶ **Persuasive**: easily able to make people do or believe things.
- ▶ **Encouraging**: giving people the feeling that they can be successful.
- ▶ **Supportive**: giving help and care in a particular situation.

In English, we often use the **past tense and the second conditional** to sound more polite and diplomatic. Here are some examples:

- ▶ If you **send** me the document by noon, I **will** appreciate it. > If you **could** send me the document by noon, I **would** really appreciate it.
- ▶ **Do** you need me to explain this again? > **Did** you need me to explain this again?
- ▶ I **hope** you **can** join us for the meeting. > I **was hoping** you **could** join us for the meeting.

We also use expressions such as **seem, apparently, as far as I know** and **it appears that** to make statements sound less direct or certain. Here are some examples:

- ▶ Mark didn't attend the meeting this morning. > **As far as I know**, Mark didn't attend the meeting this morning.
- ▶ The delivery will be delayed. > **It appears that** the delivery will be delayed.
- ▶ Emma missed the deadline for the report. > **It seems that** Emma missed the deadline for the report.
- ▶ David lost his phone at the airport. > **Apparently**, David lost his phone at the airport.

To finish this topic, there are still some other useful phrases you can use in meetings, that will definitely make you stand out:

- ▶ **Make a start without them** (empezar sin ellos): begin the meeting without waiting for absent people. *Since James and Lucy are running late, let's make a start without them.*
- ▶ **A lot to get through** (mucho por tratar): many tasks or topics to address within a limited time. *We have a lot to get through today, so let's keep our discussions short and to the point.*

- ▶ **See where we are** (evaluar el progreso o la situación): assess the current status of a task or situation. *Before making any decisions, let's see where we are with the current project.*
- ▶ **Tie up any remaining loose ends** (atar cabos sueltos, resolver los últimos detalles): fix small unresolved issues before completing something. *We're almost ready to sign the contract, but we need to tie up any remaining loose ends first.*
- ▶ **Stick to the agenda** (seguir el orden del día): followed the planned schedule and avoid unrelated discussions. *I know this is an important topic, but let's stick to the agenda so we don't run out of time.*
- ▶ **Get the ball rolling** (empezar oficialmente la reunión): initiate a discussion or activity. *Let's get the ball rolling by reviewing last week's meeting.*
- ▶ **Going through the list of action points** (revisar los puntos principales uno por uno): examine each task or decision step by step. *We should start by going through the list of action points from the last meeting.*
- ▶ **Look into** (investigar o examinar algo con más detalle): investigate a matter to gain more understanding or find a solution. *We need to look into why sales have dropped this term.*
- ▶ **Came up** (salir en la conversación, mencionarse): something was brought up or mentioned unexpectedly in a conversation. *The issue of budget cuts came up during the discussion.*

Effective tips

How to run an effective meeting

In the In Depth section, you can find a very interesting video on how to run a meeting effectively following 5 simple tips.

3.4. Grammar check

Future tenses

In English, **there are several ways to talk about the future**. We don't just use one future tense, instead, we have different structures that express different shades of meaning. Let's explore them one by one.

FUTURE SIMPLE (WILL)		
Uses: • Predictions without evidence: I think it will rain tomorrow. • Spontaneous decisions: I think I will go to Granada this summer. • Promises or offers: I will help you with your homework.		
Affirmative	Negative	Interrogative
Subject + Will + Base Verb	Subj + Will not (won't) + base verb	Will + subj + base verb?

Figure 1. Future with will. Source: author original.

FUTURE WITH "BE GOING TO"		
Uses: • Plans or intentions: I'm going to start a new course next month. • Predictions based on evidence: Look at those clouds! It's going to rain.		
Affirmative	Negative	Interrogative
I am going to work You are going to work He / She / It is going to work We are going to work You are going to work They are going to work	I am not going to work You aren't going to work He / She / It isn't going to work We aren't going to work You aren't going to work They aren't going to work	Am I going to work? Are you going to work? Is he / she / it going to work? Are we going to work? Are you going to work? Are they going to work?

Figure 2. Future with be going to. Source: author original.

FUTURE CONTINUOUS (WILL BE + ING)		
Uses: • Actions in progress at a specific time in the future: By this time tomorrow, I will be flying to New York. • Polite inquiries about someone's plans: Will you be using your car tonight?		
Affirmative	Negative	Interrogative
Subject + will be + verb (-ing)	Subject + will not be (won't be) + verb (-ing)	Will + subject + be + verb (-ing)?

Figure 3. Future continuous. Source: author original.

FUTURE PERFECT (WILL HAVE + PP)		
Uses: • Actions completed before a specific time in the future: By next year, I will have finished my degree. • Expectations about completed actions: She will have arrived home by now.		
Affirmative	Negative	Interrogative
Subject + will have + past participle	Subject + will not have (won't have) + past participle	Will + subject + have + past participle?

Figure 4. Future perfect. Source: author original.

Passive voice

The passive voice is **used when the focus is on the action rather than the person or thing performing the action**. In other words, the object of the active sentence becomes the subject of the passive sentence.

The passive voice is **formed** using the **verb “to be”** in the correct **tense + the past participle of the main verb**. To transform an active sentence into a passive one, you need to:

- ▶ Identify the subject, verb and object.
- ▶ Move the object of the active sentence to the subject position.
- ▶ Use the correct form of the verb “to be” in the same tense as the active verb.
- ▶ Use the past participle of the main verb.
- ▶ If necessary, mention the original subject using “by”.

For example:

- ▶ **Active:** The teacher **explained** the lesson.
- ▶ **Passive:** The lesson **was explained** (by the teacher).

TENSE	ACTIVE	PASSIVE
PRESENT SIMPLE	She writes a book.	A book is written (by her).
PRESENT CONTINUOUS	They are cleaning the room.	The room is being cleaned.
PAST SIMPLE	He repaired the car.	The car was repaired
PAST CONTINUOUS	They were painting the house	The house was being painted
PRESENT PERFECT	She has finished the project	The project has been finished
PAST PERFECT	They had completed the task	The task had been completed
FUTURE SIMPLE	They will announce the results	The results will be announced
FUTURE PERFECT	She will have sent the invitations	The invitations will have been sent
MODAL VERBS	You must follow the rules	The rules must be followed

Table 8. Passive voice. Source: author original.

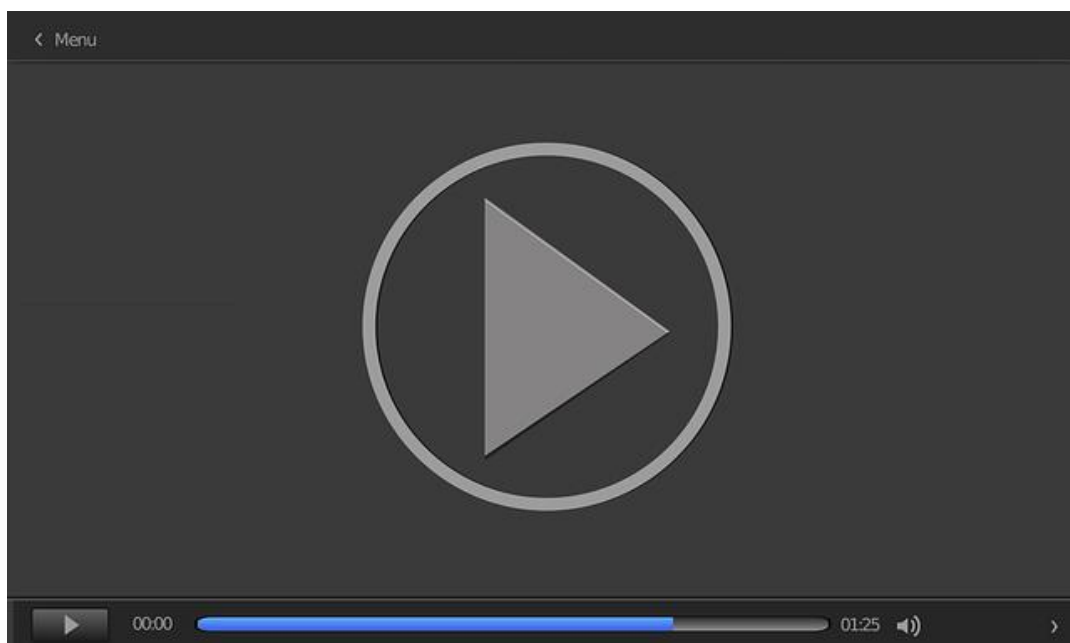
We use the passive voice in different situations:

- ▶ **When the doer is unknown, unimportant or obvious:** A new shopping mall has been opened. (We don't know who opened it, it's not important).
- ▶ **To be more formal or impersonal:** Mistakes were made. (More neutral and indirect than saying "We made mistakes").
- ▶ **In scientific or technical writing:** The experiment was conducted in a laboratory.
- ▶ **To emphasise the action rather than the person doing it:** A cure for the disease has been discovered.

How to present your ideas clearly

Carl Kwan. (2016, 26 julio). *How to Present Your Ideas Clearly - A 3 Step Process* [Video]. YouTube. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=avew5rVAwi0>

This is a very interesting video on how to present your ideas clearly following three simple steps: watch your language, talk like a person and find a guinea pig.



Accede al vídeo:

<https://www.youtube.com/embed/avew5rVAwi0>

Know their culture

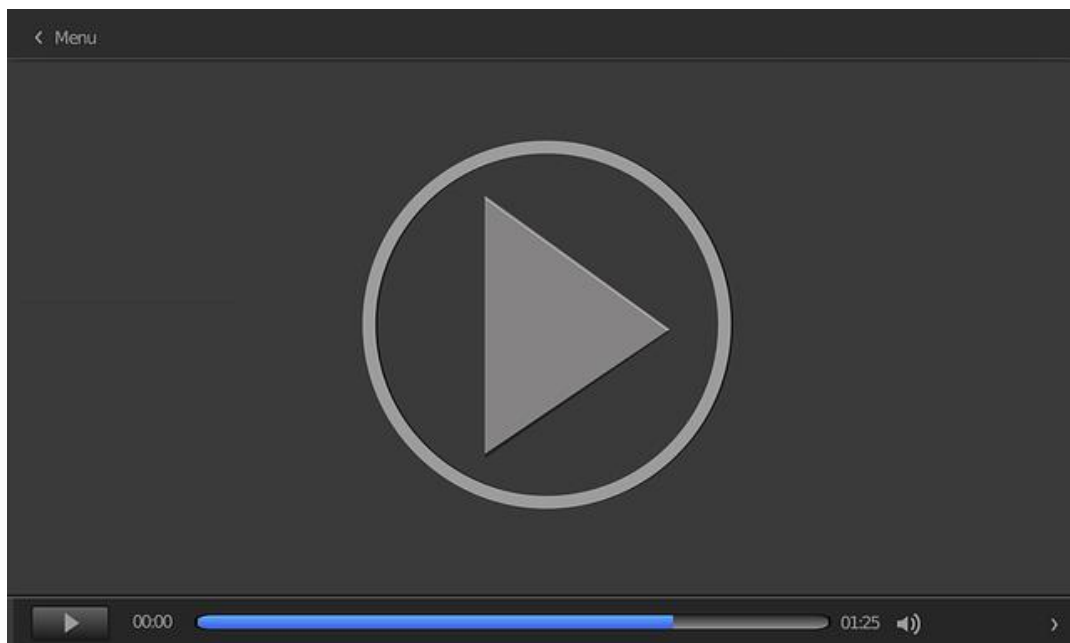
Fallon-O'Leary, D. (2025, 19 febrero). *International Business Etiquette From Around the World*. Business.com. <https://www.business.com/articles/so-international-business-etiquette-from-around-the-world/>

This is a very interesting article on some international business etiquette around the world that you may find helpful if you have a meeting in a foreign country.

How to run an effective meeting

Communication Coach Alexander Lyon. (2023, 2 mayo). *How to Run an Effective Meeting 5 Tips* [Video]. YouTube. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=iQsw3cdJbbM>

This is a very interesting video on how to run an effective meeting following 5 simple tips



Accede al vídeo:

<https://www.youtube.com/embed/iQsw3cdJbbM>

Entrenamiento 1. Oral presentations.

- ▶ Write a short text on a topic of your choice using the expressions we have seen in the unit.
- ▶ Before starting, remember to review the different expressions we have seen to start the presentation, give examples, change the topic, summarize and conclude.

Solution 1

There is no single solution for this activity, so here is an example of a possible answer:

Hello everyone! **Today I'm going to tell you about** our new smart assistant feature in our customer support system. **Let's start with** the most important thing: how it works. Instead of waiting in a queue to speak with an agent, you can simply type or say your question, and the smart assistant will provide an instant response—as easy as that! **Let me show you an example** of how the smart assistant works. I type: *"How do I track my order?"* **As you can see** on the screen, it immediately gives me the tracking information, without needing to call customer service. **Now I'd like to turn** to some numbers. On average, customers wait about five minutes to speak with a human agent. In contrast, the smart assistant provides answers in less than two seconds. **Let's move on to** how this can affect our customers' experience. We expect that customer satisfaction ratings will improve by at least 15% this quarter. And who knows? That might mean fewer complaints and happier employees—ha ha. **I'll sum up** by saying that this feature is all about efficiency. It will make responses quicker, customers more satisfied, and our support team more productive. Do you have any questions?

Entrenamiento 2. Linkers of contrast.

Fill in the gaps with the correct linker of contrast.

- ▶ 1. She studied very hard for the exam, _____ (however/but/despite) she didn't get a high score.
- ▶ 2. _____ (Although/Despite/However) his lack of experience, he was given the job.
- ▶ 3. The hotel was small. _____, (Nevertheless/but/In spite of) it was very comfortable.
- ▶ 4. _____ (Despite/On the other hand/Although) he is rich, he doesn't like to show off.
- ▶ 5. I love living in the city. _____, (On the other hand/Despite/But) my brother prefers the countryside.
- ▶ 6. _____ (Despite/Although/However) working long hours, she always finds time for her family.
- ▶ 7. The weather was terrible. _____, (But/However/Even though) they decided to go on the trip.

Solution 2

- ▶ 1. She studied very hard for the exam, **but** she didn't get a high score.
- ▶ 2. **Despite** his lack of experience, he was given the job.
- ▶ 3. The hotel was small. **Nevertheless**, it was very comfortable.
- ▶ 4. **Although** he is rich, he doesn't like to show off.

- ▶ 5. I love living in the city. **On the other hand**, my brother prefers the countryside.
- ▶ 6. **Despite** working long hours, she always finds time for her family.
- ▶ 7. The weather was terrible. **However**, they decided to go on the trip.

Entrenamiento 3. Diplomatic language.

Transform the sentences to make them more diplomatic. Rewrite the following sentences using past tenses, second conditionals or diplomatic expressions such as “it appears that”, “it seems that”, “apparently” or “as far as I know”.

- ▶ 1. You need to finish the report today.
- ▶ 2. We don't have your payment yet.
- ▶ 3. Can you send me the document now?
- ▶ 4. We have a problem with the delivery.
- ▶ 5. You forgot to attach the file.
- ▶ 6. If you come to today's meeting, I will be grateful.

Solution 3

There is no single solution for this activity, because the same sentence can be diplomatically rewritten in many ways. However, here I give you examples of possible solutions:

- ▶ 1. **Could you finish** the report today?
- ▶ 2. **It appears that** we don't have your payment yet.
- ▶ 3. **Could** you send me the document **as soon as possible, please?**
- ▶ 4. **Apparently**, we have a problem with the delivery.
- ▶ 5. **It seems that** you forgot to attach the file.
- ▶ 6. If you **could come** to today's meeting, I **would** be very grateful.

Entrenamiento 4. Future tenses.

Fill in the blanks with the correct future tense. Choose between future with will, be going to, future continuous or future perfect.

- ▶ 1. Look at those dark clouds! It _____ (rain) soon.
- ▶ 2. I think she _____ (pass) the exam, she's very smart.
- ▶ 3. This time next week, we _____ (travel) around Italy.
- ▶ 4. I forgot to buy milk! - No worries, I _____ (get) some on my way home.
- ▶ 5. She _____ (move) to New York next year, she has already booked the flight tickets.
- ▶ 6. By 10 am tomorrow, I _____ (finish) a meeting with my manager.
- ▶ 7. By 2035, scientists _____ (develop) a more advanced technology for space travel.
- ▶ 8. We _____ (visit) my grandparents this weekend. It's all planned!
- ▶ 9. I promise I _____ (help) you with your project later.

Solution 4

- ▶ 1. Look at those dark clouds! It **is going to rain** (rain) soon. (predictions based on evidence)
- ▶ 2. I think she **will pass** (pass) the exam, she's very smart. (predictions based on opinion, not evidence)
- ▶ 3. This time next week, we **will be travelling** (travel) around Italy. (actions in progress at a specific time in the future)

- ▶ 4. I forgot to buy milk! - No worries, I **will get** (get) some on my way home.
(spontaneous decisions)
- ▶ 5. She **is going to move** (move) to New York next year, she has already booked the flight tickets. (plans in the future)
- ▶ 6. By 10 am tomorrow, I **will have finished** (finish) a meeting with my manager.
(completed actions before a certain point in the future)
- ▶ 7. By 2035, scientists **will have developed** (develop) a more advanced technology for space travel. (completed actions before a certain point in the future).
- ▶ 8. We **are going to visit** (visit) my grandparents this weekend. It's all planned! (plans in the future)
- ▶ 9. I promise I **will help** (help) you with your project later. (promises and offers).

Entrenamiento 5. Passive voice.

Change the sentences from active to passive voice.

- ▶ 1. They deliver the packages every morning.
- ▶ 2. The manager will sign the contract tomorrow.
- ▶ 3. She wrote the report last night.
- ▶ 4. The company is launching a new product next month.
- ▶ 5. The police have arrested the suspect.
- ▶ 6. The government is building a new hospital in the city.
- ▶ 7. People speak English in many countries.
- ▶ 8. They will announce the results soon.

Solution 5

- ▶ 1. They deliver the packages every morning. > The packages **are delivered** every morning.
- ▶ 2. The manager will sign the contract tomorrow. > The contract **will be signed** tomorrow.
- ▶ 3. She wrote the report last night. > The report **was written** last night.
- ▶ 4. The company is launching a new product next month. > A new **product is being launched** next month.
- ▶ 5. The police have arrested the suspect. > The suspect **has been arrested**.

- ▶ 6. The government is building a new hospital in the city. > A new **hospital is being built** in the city.
- ▶ 7. People speak English in many countries. > English **is spoken** in many countries.
- ▶ 8. They will announce the results soon. > The results **will be announced** soon